Army

Shivaji gave utmost attention to his army and training of its personnel. In the beginning, the backbone of his army was the infantry. But as his campaigns extended into the plains, his cavalry grew in size and importance. Every soldier was selected personally by Shivaji and was taken into service on the assurance of a soldier already in service. Shivaji took great care in the maintenance and security of his forts. Retired captains holding a high reputation were put in charge of guarding the forts.

Ashtapradhan

Shivaji designated eight ministers as the Ashtapradhan, each holding an important portfolio. Peshwa was the equivalent of a modern prime minister in the Maratha Empire. Originally, they were subordinates to the Chhatrapati. But, in course of time, especially from the time of Sahu Maharaja, Peshwa became the de facto Maratha ruler while the Chhatrapati was reduced to the position of a nominal ruler.

Shivaji was influenced by the Mughal revenue system. The assessments were made on the actual yield, with three-fifths left to the cultivator and two-fifths taken by the government. In judicial administration, civil cases continued to be decided by the panchayat, the village council, while criminal law was based on the shastras, the Hindu law books.

Responsibilities of the Ashtapradhan

Pantpradhan / Peshwa	Prime Minister
Amatya / Mazumdar	Finance Minister
Shurunavis/Sacheev	Secretary
Waqia-Navis	Interior Minister
Sar-i-Naubat / Senapati	Commander-in-Chief
Sumant / Dubeer	Foreign Minister
Nyayadhish	Chief Justice
Panditrao	High Priest

Shambhuji

Shambhuji succeeded Shivaji after a succession tussle with Anaji Datto. There were family feuds splintering the Maratha kingdom. Durgadas of Rathore Marwar and Aurangzeb's rebel son Akbar arrived in Maharashtra and took shelter in Shambhuji's court. Aurangzeb viewed these developments very seriously and took all out efforts to finish off Shambhuji. Marathas under Shambhuji were in no position to resist the Mughals. Aurangzeb himself arrived in the Deccan in 1681. Aurangzeb's main goal was the annexation of Bijapur and Golconda. These two sultanates fell to Aurangzeb by 1687. In little over a year, Shambhuji was captured by the Mughals and, after torture, put to death.



Shambhuji

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